Making the Invisible Visible

With *Firaaq* and *Manto*, **NANDITA DAS** earned her stripes as a filmmaker. As she now prepares to take *Zwigato* to the Toronto International Film Festival (TIFF), Das deconstructs her latest film for us



Q. How would you describe *Zwigato*?
The rise of the gig economy saw the struggle between man and machine shift to one between man and algorithms. *Zwigato* makes the invisible visible. The gig workers, the female protagonist who is working for the first time, the normalised biases of class, caste, and gender—they all subtly find a way into the film.

Q. What does the TIFF selection mean for you and your film?
It means a lot, as I have debuted at TIFF both as an actor and director, with *Fire* (1996) and *Firaaq* (2008), respectively. I hope the universality of the theme will resonate with the discerning audience that the festival attracts from all over the world and also create a buzz within India.

Q. How did you come to cast Kapil Sharma, the comedian?
The pandemic's impact on actor availability and shooting times had made casting a nightmare. Just as I was about to give up, Kapil popped up. From the snippets of his show that I had seen, his simplicity and candour seemed perfect for this character. The warmth with which he approached it was just right, too. Despite the fact that he is no longer a common man, I believe he fully represents him.

Q. What made you choose Bhubaneswar as the setting?
My father is from Odisha. I am half-Odia but I am always mistaken to be a Bengali. Mainly because people know so little about culturally rich Odisha. When I was thinking of setting my story in a relatively smaller city, I thought of Bhubaneswar. It's a beautiful city and an important character in the film.

—with Udita Jhunjhunwala

Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH